

AI-Generated Content Affecting Your Freedom

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Executive Summary

Generative artificial intelligence (AI) can now produce text, images, video, and audio that are difficult to distinguish from content made by humans. This report examines how AI-generated content affects three areas of personal and civic freedom: the ability to trust information, the ability to own and control creative work, and the ability to control one's own image, voice, and personal data. Research drawn from government agencies, international regulators, and peer-reviewed sources shows that synthetic media increases the risk of misinformation and manipulation, complicates copyright and ownership law, and enables non-consensual use of a person's likeness. The report also reviews the safeguards currently being developed to address these risks, including government regulation, content labeling and detection tools, and public media literacy efforts. The findings indicate that while generative AI offers significant benefits, it also introduces measurable threats to individual freedom that require continued attention from policymakers, technology companies, and the public.

Introduction

Artificial intelligence systems capable of generating original text, images, video, and audio have moved from research labs into everyday use over the past several years. Tools that once required specialized skill can now produce a realistic photograph, a synthetic voice recording, or a full news article from a short text prompt. This shift has clear benefits for productivity and creativity, but it also raises a serious question: what happens to individual freedom when it becomes difficult to tell what is real?

This report investigates that question by focusing on AI-generated content and its effect on personal freedom. Freedom, in this context, is understood broadly to include the freedom to trust the information used to make decisions, the freedom to own and benefit from one's creative work, and the freedom to control one's own image, voice, and personal data. As generative AI tools become faster, cheaper, and more widely available, each of these freedoms faces new pressure.

The purpose of this report is to examine the specific ways AI-generated content threatens these freedoms and to identify the safeguards currently being developed in response. The scope of the report covers three primary risk areas: misinformation and manipulation, ownership and creative rights, and privacy and consent. It then reviews policy, technical, and personal-level protections currently in use or in development.

Methodology

This report is based on a review of ten sources identified during the research phase of this project and previously presented in an APA-formatted reference list. The sources were selected to represent a range of perspectives on AI-generated content, including federal regulatory

guidance, international policy frameworks, peer-reviewed academic journal articles, and reference material from established publishers.

Sources include publications from U.S. federal agencies such as the Government Accountability Office, the Federal Trade Commission, and the National Institute of Standards and Technology, each of which addresses accountability, consumer protection, or risk management related to AI systems. International perspective is provided through the European Union Agency for Fundamental Rights and the World Economic Forum. Academic analysis is drawn from peer-reviewed articles in MIT Sloan Management Review and Communications of the ACM, accessed through the Business Source Complete and ProQuest research databases. Reference material from Encyclopaedia Britannica and Oxford Reference was used to establish foundational definitions and background context, and a Library of Congress legislative overview provided data on the scale of the issue.

Each source was reviewed for relevance to one or more of the three research questions guiding this report: How does AI-generated content affect the public's ability to trust information? How does it affect ownership of creative work? How does it affect personal privacy and consent? Findings from each source were then grouped by theme and synthesized into the findings section below. This approach allowed the report to draw connections across government, industry, and academic viewpoints rather than relying on a single type of source.

Findings

The research identified three primary areas in which AI-generated content places pressure on individual freedom: trust in information, ownership of creative work, and privacy and consent. A fourth theme, protective measures, describes the safeguards currently being developed to address these risks.

Freedom of Informed Choice: Truth and Trust

The most immediate risk associated with AI-generated content is its effect on the public's ability to trust information. Deepfake videos and cloned voices can now make it appear that a real person said or did something they never did, and AI-generated news articles and social media posts can spread false information quickly and at a large scale. The Library of Congress reported that 2024 marked a record year for AI-generated deepfakes used in political and financial scams worldwide, indicating that this is not a hypothetical risk but one already affecting elections, financial markets, and individual victims of fraud.

Encyclopaedia Britannica's overview of artificial intelligence and misinformation describes a related effect sometimes called the "liar's dividend": as the public becomes aware that any image, video, or quote could be fabricated, it becomes easier for people to dismiss authentic evidence as fake. This erodes trust in real information alongside fabricated information, which directly threatens the freedom of informed choice that underlies activities such as voting, purchasing decisions, and everyday judgment about what to believe. The Government Accountability Office's review of AI accountability practices similarly emphasizes that without reliable oversight mechanisms, AI systems can undermine public trust in the institutions and information sources that democratic decision-making depends on.

Freedom of Ownership and Creativity

A second area of concern involves the ownership of creative work. Generative AI models are trained on large volumes of existing text, art, music, and photographs, often without the consent or compensation of the original creators. Samuelson's analysis of generative AI and creative rights, published in *Communications of the ACM*, explains that this training process allows an artist's or writer's style to be replicated without credit, which can result in lost income

when AI-generated output replaces work that would otherwise have been commissioned from a human creator. Creators frequently have no clear way to determine whether their work was used for training or to opt out of future use.

This uncertainty extends to the users of AI-generated content as well. Courts and regulators are still determining who owns AI-generated output, which creates legal risk for individuals or businesses that use such content commercially. As Samuelson notes, copyright law was written before generative AI existed and was not designed to address questions of authorship when a machine, rather than a person, produces the final work. Until this legal framework catches up with the technology, both creators and users face reduced freedom to protect or confidently use creative material.

Freedom of Privacy and Consent

The third area identified in this research concerns privacy and personal consent. Generative AI can now produce a realistic image, video, or voice recording of a real person without ever asking their permission. The European Union Agency for Fundamental Rights identifies non-consensual deepfakes, in which a person's face or voice is placed into content they never agreed to appear in, as a direct risk to both privacy and freedom of expression.

This risk is compounded by how AI models are built in the first place. Personal posts, photographs, and writing are frequently scraped from the internet to train these systems, often without the knowledge of the people who created them, a concern echoed in the Federal Trade Commission's policy statement on commercial surveillance and AI-driven content. The World Economic Forum's analysis of algorithmic bias adds that these same data practices can produce biased profiles of individuals that affect decisions made about them. Davenport's study in MIT Sloan Management Review extends this concern into the workplace, finding that AI monitoring

tools can analyze employee behavior and generate detailed behavioral profiles without clear consent, reducing employee autonomy even in professional settings governed by an employer rather than the open internet.

Protective Measures

The research also identified safeguards being developed at both the policy and personal levels to address these risks. At the policy level, the FTC, the European Union, and the National Institute of Standards and Technology are each building rules and risk-management frameworks intended to govern AI-driven content. NIST's AI Risk Management Framework, for example, provides organizations with a structured process for identifying and reducing the risks associated with deploying AI systems, while Oxford Reference's overview of AI ethics situates these frameworks within a broader philosophical discussion of human agency and responsible technology design.

At the technical level, watermarking and detection tools are being developed to help flag AI-generated media, giving platforms and users a way to identify synthetic content before it spreads. At the personal level, media literacy remains an important line of defense: checking sources and verifying content before sharing it reduces the spread of fabricated material, even when technical detection tools are imperfect or not yet widely deployed. Taken together, these three layers of protection, regulation, detection, and literacy, represent the current best response to the risks identified in this report, though each is still developing in response to a technology that continues to advance quickly.

Conclusion

AI-generated text, images, video, and audio are now fast, cheap to produce, and widely available. This capability creates real, documented risk to three distinct freedoms: the freedom to trust the information used to make decisions, the freedom to own and benefit from creative work, and the freedom to control one's own image, voice, and personal data. Evidence from federal and international regulators, academic research, and reference sources consistently supports this conclusion, from the record levels of political and financial deepfake scams reported by the Library of Congress to the copyright uncertainty described by Samuelson and the workplace monitoring concerns raised by Davenport.

At the same time, the research shows that safeguards are actively being built to respond to these risks. Regulatory frameworks from agencies such as the FTC and NIST, technical tools for labeling and detecting synthetic media, and everyday media literacy practices each address a different part of the problem. No single safeguard is sufficient on its own; regulation moves slowly relative to the pace of the technology, detection tools are not always reliable, and media literacy depends on individual behavior that cannot be mandated. Continued attention from policymakers, technology companies, and the public will be necessary to keep these protections aligned with the capabilities of generative AI as it continues to advance. Individuals can take an immediate, practical step by adopting the habit recommended throughout this research: stay curious, stay critical, and verify before trusting AI-generated content.

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